95 per cent marks in her Class 12 boards may or may not make it to the institution of choice, but has a fair chance in an international university ranked among the top 50, and with a scholarship to boot. Covid and CUET, however, are only the immediate reasons for students forsaking Indian universities and looking beyond. The roots of the problem go far deeper, into the cavernous hole that is the Indian education system itself.

Gaps in Our Education

It is the dinosaur in the room no one wishes to acknowledge. But the fact remains that Indian pedagogy has failed to rise above textbook and classroom learning, and teaching a syllabus that puts students to sleep, rather than awakening their interest. No one knows this better than Dinesh Singh, the former vice-chancellor of Delhi University and now the chancellor of K.R. Mangalam University, Gurugram. "Our education system does not deliver what it should despite all effort," he says. "There is a lack of practical knowledge at undergraduate levels, which is why most students feel that courses available with universities here are meaningless. The universities and education abroad, on the other hand, let them express themselves, be critical, offer useful and practical knowledge."

It's a view 19-year-old Saiba Bajaj echoes. She is currently majoring in Computer Science at the University of Manitoba, Canada, and loving the experience. "In an international university," she says, "there is a marked difference in the application of concepts learnt during the degree programme. The idea of being actually able to utilise and apply those concepts was fascinating for me."

A limited choice of subjects and specialisations, poor facilities and the absence of good teachers are other deterrents, especially in colleges away from the metros. "The Indian education ecosystem is narrow," says Poonam Verma, professor-principal of the Shaheed Sukhdev College of Business Studies, University of Delhi. "The young today are experimental in nature and want to explore a different set-up." Tumul Buch, co-founder of Yocket, agrees. "Gen Z wants to pursue new-age and offbeat courses," he says. And Indian universities just do not have them.

Students, therefore, are opting for courses, disciplines and specialisations abroad that are in sync with industry and up to date with technological advancements and sensitive to societal needs. As Professor Charlie Jeffery, vice-chancellor, University of York, UK,



RAJWANT RAWAT

AKSHAT SETHI, *17, Delhi*

» **GOING FOR:** Integrated Master's in Aeronautical Engineering, Imperial College London, UK

» **WHY HE WANTS TO GO**

"I have a knack for STEM, like to build things and love to code and at the same time explore my passions and multiple interests. Keeping all that in mind, the decision to study abroad was the most natural one for me"



"PARENTS FEEL THAT WITH THE GROWING MOBILITY IN THE JOB MARKET, A MULTICULTURAL UNIVERSITY EXPERIENCE EQUIPS THEIR CHILDREN BETTER FOR SUCCESS"

– SUNEET SINGH KOCHAR,
CEO, Fateh Education